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Teaching Portfolio

I am an effective teacher who is committed to improving my skills and making the university more inclusive. Over the last year, I have taken three elective courses at TMU's Centre for Excellence in Learning and Teaching and I am currently participating in a mentorship program at NYU, providing guidance to an undergraduate student from an underrepresented group on her graduate school applications. In 2023, I was awarded the Dean's Outstanding Graduate Student Teaching Award, an honor only given to one doctoral student across the social sciences at NYU.

Teaching Philosophy

My teaching philosophy is based on three principles. First, the learning experience should build students' confidence in their own ability to learn. When I first taught coding to undergraduate students, I received many emails requesting help with problems that could be solved through an internet search and some persistence. Knowing that simply providing solutions to students would not help them solve future problems on their own, I set aside time in our next class to brainstorm effective methods for getting past roadblocks they faced in learning to code. I then had students work in pairs to use these trial-and-error strategies to debug a program I had a set up. Throughout the rest of the term, students showed greater initiative and often attempted several approaches on their own before seeking help. In their written evaluations, students said they valued being "[led] in the right direction without giving me the answer."

Learning should also be creative and interactive where possible, pushing students to explore concepts beyond rote memorization and to co-construct knowledge with their peers. In political science we often use a simple mathematical model to illustrate citizens' (dis)incentives to turn out in elections. After explaining this material, I have students work in groups to design a "get out the vote" poster that targets one of the model's algebraic parameters (e.g. by shifting a voter's belief that their vote will make a difference) and explain how their messaging should affect the choice of the voter. Students describe this approach as both effective and engaging, and appreciate the opportunity to translate what are sometimes abstract ideas into real world phenomena. I also notice that students who are typically hesitant to participate become more comfortable speaking up after they first have an opportunity to interact with their peers in a smaller group setting.

Finally, learning should help students appreciate the value of diverse viewpoints. In my courses, I ensure that a significant proportion of the assigned readings are written by authors from historically marginalized groups. In my class on race and politics, I also highlight empirical research illustrating how gender and racial diversity among elected officials can improve governance outcomes. As a person whose identity affords them multiple intersecting privileges, reading these works expanded my own understanding of marginalization in unexpected ways. By presenting a variety of perspectives to students, my goals are for them to see themselves represented in the academy and to learn from those with different lived experiences. In sum, my pedagogical strategies are informed by a respect for student's agency in the learning process, encouraging them to push through challenges, translate course material to the real world, and evaluate new arguments for themselves.

Teaching Experience and Evaluations

I began teaching at the university-level during the final years of my Bachelor's degree and have now worked as a teaching assistant for ten courses. During my time at McGill, I developed and taught an extra-curricular course for political science undergraduates, "Introduction to R for Data Science," which was so well-received that subsequent instructors continued offering the course based on my materials after I had graduated.

Of the 184 evaluations I have received, over 93% have been positive and less than 1% were negative. On average, I received a score of 4.68/5 for the seven courses I taught at New York University and McGill University (evaluations were not available for the courses I taught during my undergraduate degree at the University of Waterloo):

- Comparative Politics (Undergraduate), New York University, Spring 2022 and 2023, Evaluations: 4.66 and 4.69/5
- International Politics (Undergraduate), New York University, Fall 2021 and 2022, Evaluations: 4.89 and 4.65/5
- Introduction to Quantitative Political Science (Undergraduate), McGill University, Fall 2016 and Winter 2018, Evaluations: 4.33 and 4.66/5
- African Politics (Undergraduate), McGill University, Winter 2017, Evaluations: 4.41/5
- Planning Administration and Finance (Undergraduate), University of Waterloo, Fall 2014 and 2015, Evaluations: Not available.
- Professional Communication (Undergraduate), University of Waterloo, Winter 2013, Evaluations: Not available.

Figure 1 summarizes my teaching evaluation scores across different qualities on which students were asked to evaluate me. Table 1 presents quotes from written evaluations to illustrate my core competencies as a teacher.

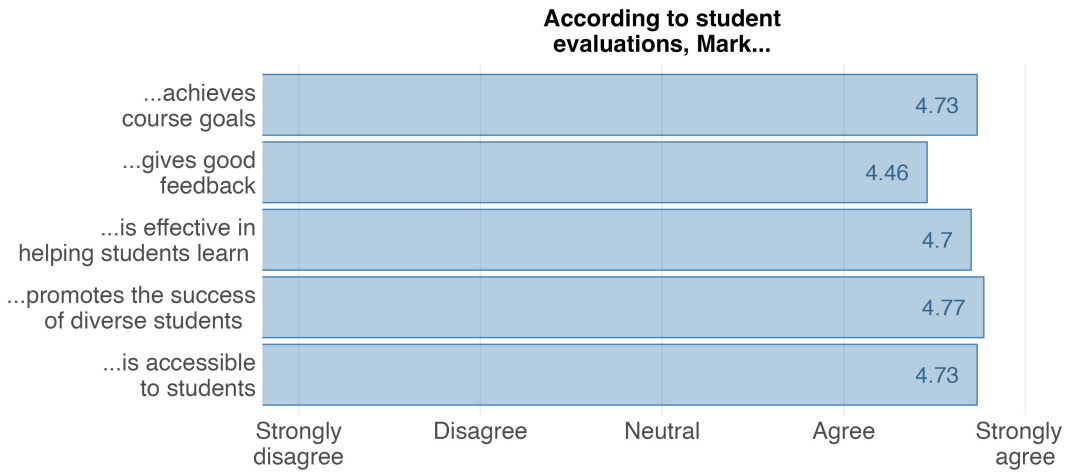

Figure 1: Average student evaluation score by quality evaluated, 2017 to 2023

Table 1: Qualitative Written Evaluations

Trait	**Evidence from student comments**
Accessible	• Mark was one of the best TA I had! He was reachable for questions either in conferences or during his office hours. He had great advice and even sent us a documentary on the subject that interested us by email.
	• He helped me review my final project and even did research after our conversation, and emailed me back with examples he found that could help my project. He went above and beyond!
	• Mark is super accessible and understanding. I have little math experience and he was super helpful and even carved out extra time for me.
Clear	• Because he explained the logic behind each mathematical equation, I was better able to remember how to correctly solve the equation and why the equation was important in the context of international politics.
	• Mark was able to take the complicated subject matter and break down the concepts into digestible information.
	• The way Mark covered topics was concise yet extremely eye opening. He gave us ways to remember topics and even understand ones that had seemed convoluted and complicated.
Engaging	• Engaged in student commentary rather than giving a brief "mm-hmm" and moving on to the next student.
	• Makes some generally uninteresting topics very engaging by creating a very clear connection to the real world.
	• Having us often work in pairs/groups was effective in helping me learn as it facilitated the exchange of ideas and knowledge.
Encouraging	• Being a student with dyslexia and ADHD, Mr. Williamson was patient to help me overcome the game theory part of the course. With my learning disabilities, [his] teaching style allowed me to understand and genuinely learn the materials.
	• He always made time for questions and never let anyone feel bad for being confused or not understanding something.
	• Mark was very willing to clarify any questions students had and was very good at introducing challenging new topics to us in a non-intimidating way.
Challenging	• He walked through practice problems and asked us to answer them instead of just showing us how to do it, which was very helpful. He made sure we were involved.
	• He was able to lead me in the right direction without giving me the answer (helping me learn how to figure out things on my own).

Plans for Future Courses

My areas of teaching expertise include Canadian politics; comparative politics; race, ethnicity and politics; political behaviour; and research methods. The following are descriptions of classes that I am particularly eager to teach:

1. **Introduction to Canadian Politics** (Undergraduate): This course provides a general introduction to the study of Canadian politics and government. We begin by characterizing the institutional framework of Canada, focusing on colonialism, the constitution, federalism, the electoral system, political parties, parliament, the bureaucracy, and the courts. We then turn to a consideration of the context within which politics takes place, investigating political culture, diversity and multiculturalism and interest groups. Throughout the course, we integrate discussions about the role of women, racialized groups, and Indigenous peoples in Canadian politics. In a capstone project, students will use social media to teach a course concept to others.

2. **Introduction to Research Methods**(Undergraduate/Graduate): Which voters are more likely to turn out to cast a ballot? How do we know if a government policy actually worked? This course introduces foundational concepts in research design, statistics and data science as a way to answer the most important questions in politics and public policy. The class begins with an exploration of what makes a good research question and how our selection of cases, data and empirical strategy influence the answers we get. Students will develop their coding, analysis and data visualization skills using real world data. The course will also provide hands-on opportunities for exploring how qualitative research methods can complement the insights we gain from quantitative data.

3. **Political Behaviour and Public Opinion** (Undergraduate/Graduate): Why do better-educated citizens tend to vote at higher rates? How accurate are the latest polls about the government's popularity? This course explores how the mass public engages in political life. We look first at the behaviours of citizens, including why they choose to vote, why they vote for the parties that they do, and why they increasingly dislike supporters of other parties. We then turn to the beliefs and attitudes underpinning those behaviours, interrogating how voters form their opinions (and how we might try to measure those opinions!). In the course's main assignment, students will either develop a proposal for a survey instrument or analyze existing public opinion data to answer a research question that interests them. By the end of the course, students will be able to critically consume public opinion data and produce their own survey questions and research designs. A draft syllabus for this course is available at mark-williamson.github.io/teaching.

4. **Race, Racism and Politics** (Undergraduate/Graduate): Striking disparities exist in the health and socioeconomic outcomes of racialized, Indigenous and non-racialized peoples in Canada. Yet public opinion polls show that many Canadians do not believe that racism is a serious problem in their country. This course investigates the dynamics of racial hierarchies and how politics interact with those inequalities. We look at the representation of racial groups within political institutions and consider the electoral strategies of political parties on racial issues. At the individual level, we explore the causes and consequences of racial identity attachments, prejudice and beliefs about historical injustices. Students will

critique proposals for reducing racial inequality and consider how shifting demographics are likely to reshape Canadian politics in the coming decades. Throughout the course, we contextualize Canadian racial issues through comparisons to other countries.